

HR INTERVIEW

The interview is the last step for hiring and probably the most important. Interviews are conducted to assess a candidate's suitability for an organization and the hiring role.

Why an interview is conducted:

The purpose of an interview is to ascertain what a candidate has mentioned in his resume. It is a brief meeting where your technical know-how will be assessed in addition to your communication skills, motivational factors, your attitude, your goals and objectives. An interview is a two way process where an employer gets to know the prospective (to be hired) employee and an employee gains insight of the organizational and the role being offered to him.

What qualities does an interviewer observe?

a) Attitude: The most important factor that determines who gets hired and who doesn't is NOT who is best qualified, who has the most experience or skills, or who has the best resume. It is the attitude! Show positive attitude and your excitement for the job. Do not show arrogance even if you are a college topper.

b) Communication Skills: Regardless of how much of knowledge you possess, unless you know how to express yourself clearly, the interview may not turn out to be in your favor. Powerful communication skills have the ability to compensate for short coming in other areas. A candidate must speak confidently and use clear language with as little jargon as possible. His conversation with the interviewer must reflect his enthusiasm, awareness and his attitude.

c) Confidence: Approaching an interview with confidence is one of the keys of a winning strategy. Your confidence is a reflection of optimism and speaks a lot about how you would handle a challenging professional situation. Confidence is great; overconfidence is a strict no-no.

d) Body language: Good body language is an indicator on good non-verbal communication. Walk into the room with a confident smile and introduce yourself to everyone present with a firm handshake. Maintain a good posture, do not slouch, maintain eye contact, and nod your head when being talked to. Do not yawn, bite your nails, shake your limbs, look around, look down.

e) Leadership skills:

A leader always motivates. A leader directs his team towards success. When you attend an interview, make sure your interviewer knows that you are ready to take initiatives and help the members of your team.

Learnability is another sign of a good leader. Letting the interviewers know your eagerness to learn new things will prove to be a bonus for you.

f) Emotional Maturity: A candidate must be calm and composed during an interview. Sometimes, the interviewer, on purpose may provoke you by asking some unexpected questions. Do not get provoked or angry. Instead, show your maturity by answering the question in a manner that does not offend the interviewer. It is better to be honest and give direct answers instead of speaking as if you agree with all the points that the interviewer says. The given situation should be handled with ease, maturity and composure.

g) Dressing Sense: It is important to dress right for an interview. Your appearance talks loads about your personality. Wear neatly ironed formal clothes with a good pair of shoes. Women should apply minimal make up and avoid too much of jewelry. Both men and women should have well manicured nails and a professional hairstyle. Going shabbily dressed for an interview would cast an impression of your being uninterested towards the meeting.

h) Integrity: Every interviewer appreciates honesty as that is one of the main traits to look for in a candidate. Answer the questions honestly. Do not lie about your professional achievements. Be humble. Do not throw an air of arrogance. If you are appreciated for something, be gracious to say thanks.

i) Flexibility: An employer should be convinced about your ability to adapt to different situations. Show the employers that you are flexible and can adjust to different circumstances. If you are asked for example, your willingness to re-locate far away from your family for a project, mention that you would be happy doing so as your career and organization's interest are foremost priorities. How well you adjust to the situation is a trait employers look for in their employees.

j) Learnability:

Learning is a continuous process. Desire to keep learning shows an employer that you are enthusiastic about what is being offered to you. Learnability is a key to professional as well as organizational growth. You may be the best of candidates, but unless you have a thirst for knowledge, your knowledge repository may become saturated.

RESUME PREPARATION

Your resume is the most important document that the employer would refer to. Hence, it is very important to keep your resume professional and up to date. Include your professional details, academic details total work experience, skills, tools and programming languages known. Do not lie about your skills and experience. Resume should be written honestly and carefully. Do not prepare a very long resume. A short but to the point resume should be prepared. Do not copy the resume from other sources. Write it on your own although you may take reference from sample resumes.

Tips to build an effective resume

- Choose a good resume format.
- Pick up a font that is easy to read. Fonts such as Verdana, Times New Roman and Arial in sizes 10-12 are conducive for reading.
- Use the right keywords in your resume.
- Use effective titles.

Example: Bad title: Software development.

Good title: Developing Java API.

- Divide your resume into sub sections.

Example: One section for details about your work experience, the second section about your academic qualifications, the third about your skill set, the fourth about your personal profile etc.

- The most important points should be placed at the beginning of your resume. This should be uniformly followed in the individual sections as well. The most recent work experience will come first.
- Your contact details including your address telephone number and email ID should be clearly mentioned in the resume.
- Use bullet points and short sentences in your resume. Do not make the resume boring by giving in depth explanation or being repetitive.
- Avoid writing negative sentences.
- Write a few sentences about your professional goals.
- Use your testimonial references for any skill that you would like to highlight.

Example: winning a technical white paper competition at the national level (testimonials included).

- Do not include your age, unless it is specifically asked for.
- Do not create a standard resume for all the jobs to be applied to. Restructure your resume depending on the job for which you are applying.
- Do a spelling and a grammar check before you send your resume.

- Update your resume on a periodic basis.
- Mention dates in order.
- Do not forget the basics, like your name.
- Mention the employers for whom you have worked.
- Mention the companies for whom you have interned (done your projects).
- Do not use heavy vocabulary or too much of jargon(technical words).
- Get your resume reviewed by a professional.

Things to avoid when writing your resume

- Lying about past work experience or qualification.
- Committing spelling and grammatical errors.
- Making the resume colorful in appearance.
- Including too much of information.
- Not using the right keywords.
- Writing an objective that does not match the job.
- Writing old or outdated details.
- Sending a handwritten or poorly photocopied resume
- Writing long sentences and paragraphs.
- Writing about your own goals more than your abilities to match the job expectation.
- Using 'I' in the sentences.
- Writing information that would make an employer feel that you discriminate (Mentioning your age/ marital status/ number of kids/gender etc).
- Writing about hobbies(Unless your hobby would contribute to your candidature, do not include it).
- Writing incomplete information.
- Writing negative things (Like failure in delivering a project).
- Writing please ("Please give me an opportunity to work for you.")

Contents of A Good Resume

a. Personal Details: The most important detail is your name, mentioned in bold. Your contact information including email IDs and telephone numbers should be clearly written.

b. Summary: Writing an objective is a thing of the past. Instead, summarize your experience and skill set in one or two effective sentences. This would immediately grab the hiring manager's attention. E.g. Five years of experience in software quality assurance.

c. Past Work Experience: Include the details of your previous employment and briefly mention the significant projects that you were involved in. Mention the organization name and also the duration of your work. The order should be starting from recent to past.

GROUP DISCUSSION

Group Discussion is a process of selection rather than elimination. Group Discussion refers to the process where by a topic or a situation is presented to a group of candidates. It is a systematic exchange of ideas and information among a group of people. In a Group Discussion, a topic is given and each member is given about 10-15 minutes to think about the given topic. The members are then allowed to present their views and opinions to the other candidates in the group. The Group Discussion facilitates objective thinking, systematic presentation of ideas, interacting abilities, problem resolution, leadership abilities, ability to take initiatives, ability to work within a team, flexibility and assertiveness skills.

Why GD is a part of the selection process?

The primary reason for conducting the Group Discussion is to evaluate how effectively a candidate would perform as a member of a team. When more than one person is involved in problem solving, ideas have to be brainstormed, collaborated and a conclusion should be reached such that the organizational goals are met along with creating a win win situation for every member of the team. Thus apart from participation and contribution, team behavior and attitude of a person are the traits that a company would be evaluating in the Group Discussion.

The written test evaluates aptitude in Verbal Ability, Quantitative Ability and Reasoning Ability; These areas to judge the analytical, logical, numerical and language abilities but they do not test the personality traits or group behavior of the individual. The ability to deal with people, individually or in a group, is vital for success in the corporate world. Therefore a group discussion is included in the selection process. A group discussion allows the selectors to judge the individual's performance and behavior in a group. Different aspects of group discussion include communication skills- both verbal and non-verbal, Ability to make decisions and co-operate with people.

Types of Group Discussions

The classification is based on the type of the topics that are chosen for group discussion. The topics could be:

1. Current Affairs-Topics related to current news items related to business, technology, politics, education and social activities etc.

2. Argumentative Issues- A topic is given to the candidates that they have to analyze and critically present their views on the topic.

3. Factual topics- The topics are which may directly or indirectly affect a person in his day to day life.

- Women's reservation bill
- Lokpal bill
- Status of women in India
- Global warming.

4. Controversial topics- Topics in which candidates can take a stance – for or against the given topic thereby leading to a bit of disagreement among the participating members of the group.

For example,

- We are becoming too dependent on computers.
- Video games contribute to youth violence.
- Reservation system should be removed.

5. Abstract subjects- These types of topics generally include imaginary or hypothetical topics. For example,

- What would happen if the Earth would stop rotating?
- What would happen if you were given a chance to rule the country?

6. Case study- instead of a topic a case study will be given in this category. They need to resolve the situation. The objective the case study is to think about the situation from different angles. Generally real life situations are given in case study. A complex and problematic situation and information about that situation is given to the group.

Popular Group Discussion Topics

- 1) Are Advertisements Beneficial or misleading?
- 2) Balance between Professionalism and Family.
- 3) Can Trade help the poor?
- 4) Demographic Dividend in India.
- 5) Depreciation of Indian Rupee.
- 6) Is FDI good for India?
- 7) Privatization will lead to Less Corruption.
- 8) To survive in the civilized world one needs to be hypocrite.
- 9) Growth and integrity are poles apart.
- 10) Cricket Has Spoiled Other Streams Of Indian Sports.
- 11) We will never be corruption free society.
- 12) Indian Primary Education Is Pathetic.
- 13) India needs more entrepreneurs than managers to face new challenges.
- 14) Artificial Intelligence - Will man be ever replaced by machines?
- 15) Role of India in combating terrorism.